

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 47

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A teenage girl reflects on the evenings she has begun to spend reading aloud to her grandfather, whose eyesight has failed.

1

On the evening I first read to my grandfather, I was nervous in a way I had not expected. He had asked for a book of short stories that he had loved as a young man, and he had asked, very politely, as though I were a librarian he had only just met. His eyesight had been failing for three years; the doctor's most recent letter, which my mother had read aloud at the kitchen table, used phrases like **advanced macular degeneration** and **no further intervention recommended**. I was fifteen. I had read essays in class and birthday cards at parties. I had never read to a person who could not, by himself, read back.

2

I began too quickly. The first paragraph rushed past me like a bus I had failed to flag down, and at the end of it my grandfather raised one careful finger and said, in his thoughtful, unhurried way, that the word I had pronounced **quay** was in fact pronounced **key**. He did not laugh. He did not even smile. He simply offered the correction the way one might offer a cup of tea — as a kindness, neither demanded nor refused. I felt my ears grow warm, and I began the paragraph again. This time, I slowed.

3

That slowness, I have come to understand, was the lesson. My grandfather had spent his life as a teacher of literature, and although he no longer corrected my essays or marked my homework, he had not stopped teaching. He simply taught differently now. When I tripped over a sentence, he waited. When I mispronounced a place name from a country I had never seen, he murmured the correct sound, gently, as though replacing a glass on a table. He did not lecture. He listened.

4

We settled, after a few evenings, into a rhythm. I read for an hour. He sat in the armchair by the window, his hands folded over a thin blanket, his eyes closed. The eyes had given up on the visible world, but the rest of him had not. His head tilted at the funny parts. His mouth tightened, very slightly, at the sad

ones. Once or twice he murmured the name of a writer I had never heard of and asked me, afterwards, to look up a particular phrase. I always did.

5

One evening, I read him a story about a boy who walks home from school through a field of wheat in late summer. The boy stops, in the story, to listen to the rustling of the grain, and the sound reminds him of his mother singing. When I reached that sentence, my grandfather opened his eyes — which surprised me, because he so rarely did — and looked, not at me, but at the window. “Your great-grandmother,” he said, “used to sing while she shelled peas. I had not thought of that in fifty years.” He closed his eyes again. He did not ask me to continue, but I did, because the room felt as though it would tip into silence if I stopped.

6

I had imagined, at the start, that I was helping him. I had imagined that my voice, careful and patient, was a gift I was giving to a man who could no longer turn pages. By the third month, I understood that the gift was running, in fact, in the other direction. He was teaching me how to read — not the words on a page, which I had managed since I was six, but the **spaces** between them. He was teaching me to wait for the breath at the end of a long sentence, to honour a comma, to let a paragraph rest before beginning the next. He was teaching me, in short, to slow down. It is a thing the world does not often teach a fifteen-year-old.

7

On the last Friday of the term, I closed the book at the end of a chapter and asked him whether he would like me to go on. He did not answer at once. After a moment he said, very softly, that he was tired, and that the story would still be there tomorrow. I sat with him for another ten minutes anyway, in the half-dark, while the streetlights came on outside. I did not read. I did not speak. I simply waited, the way he had taught me to wait, and I understood, for the first time, what a long and patient kindness it had been.

8

He died the following spring. I keep the book on the shelf above my desk — the short stories, with the page corner folded where we had stopped. I open it sometimes, not to read, but to look at the small pencil marks in the margins, made years before my birth, in a hand I now recognise as his. I read, these days, more slowly than my classmates. I do not mind. I learned to read, properly, in an armchair by a window, beside a man whose eyes were closed.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says her grandfather asked for the book “as though I were a librarian he had only just met.” What does this comparison suggest about his manner? [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show the narrator had never done this kind of reading before. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator writes that the first paragraph “rushed past me like a bus I had failed to flag down.” Explain what this comparison tells us about how she was reading. [2]

4. The grandfather offered the correction “the way one might offer a cup of tea.” What does this comparison suggest about the **manner** of his correction? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says her grandfather “had not stopped teaching” — “He simply taught differently now.”
- (a) In what way had his teaching changed? [1]
- (b) What does this change suggest about his character? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says that her grandfather’s “eyes had given up on the visible world, but the rest of him had not.” Explain how the language used in Paragraph 4 shows that he was still fully engaged with the stories. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. When the grandfather recalls his mother singing, the narrator writes that “the room felt as though it would tip into silence if I stopped.” Explain what this phrase suggests about the **atmosphere** in the room at that moment. [2]

8. Why is it significant that the grandfather “opened his eyes” at this particular moment? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator says her grandfather was teaching her to read “the **spaces** between” the words. Explain, in your own words, what she means. [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. What is suggested by the grandfather’s comment that “the story would still be there tomorrow”? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article examining why popular songs have grown noticeably shorter over the past two decades.

1

The song on the radio is, statistically, getting shorter. According to data compiled by Billboard and the streaming analytics firm Chartmetric, the average length of a track on the United States Top 100 has fallen from around four minutes and twenty seconds in 2000 to under three minutes and ten seconds in 2024 — a drop of more than a quarter, achieved entirely within a single generation. The trend is not confined to one genre or one country. It shows up in pop, in hip-hop, in country, and in K-pop alike. Something, plainly, has changed.

2

The most cited explanation lies in the rulebook of the streaming services. On Spotify, Apple Music and their competitors, a song generates a royalty payment to its rights-holders only when a listener has played at least **thirty seconds** of it. A two-minute song that is played to completion therefore earns the same as a five-minute song played to completion — yet the shorter song is far more likely to be played again, and again, by the same listener. The arithmetic, for a record label paying its artist by the stream, is brutally simple: short songs are profitable songs.

3

The thirty-second rule also rewards a particular kind of opening. A song that has not “earned” its listener by the half-minute mark is, in commercial terms, a song that has failed. Producers now talk openly of designing the first fifteen seconds as a kind of hook-on-arrival — a recognisable melody, a memorable phrase, a beat that arrives almost before the singer does. The slow build, the gentle introduction, the patient unfolding of a chorus from a verse: all of these have grown rare. They do not, in the cold language of the platform, **convert**.

4

Some writers attribute the shortening to a broader change in the way young listeners pay attention. The phrase **attention economy** has been used so often that it has worn smooth, but the underlying claim is real enough: that a generation raised on fifteen-second videos, infinite scrolling feeds, and constant notifications has been trained, gradually, to expect rapid reward. A 2023 study by researchers at University College London suggested that the average sustained attention span on a smartphone screen, among adults under twenty-five, had fallen to under forty seconds. If the listener is no longer willing to wait for a song to develop, the song must arrive already developed.

5

Not everyone in the industry, however, is convinced that streaming is the only cause. Producer Finneas O’Connell, who has written songs with his sister Billie Eilish, has argued that the shortening has as much to do with **craft** as with commerce. Songs of the 1970s, he notes, often included long instrumental sections, full key changes, and second choruses with new lyrics — features that today’s listeners, he claims, simply do not miss. Other writers point out that the **average** length is being pulled down not only by shorter individual tracks but by an explosion of very brief songs — sub-two-minute pieces, sometimes barely sketches — that would once have been called demos, but that are now released as finished works.

6

Whether anything is lost is harder to say. A four-minute song has room, in principle, for an instrumental bridge, a key change, a second verse that surprises the first. A two-minute song does not. Critics of the trend argue that pop music is being hollowed out — that the lyrical and emotional development that once made a great song memorable has been sacrificed to the relentless logic of the play count. Defenders reply that brevity is itself a discipline. A two-minute song that earns its place is, by definition, a song

without a wasted bar; it must say what it has to say and then have the dignity to stop. The discipline, they suggest, may produce a leaner and more honest kind of pop.

7

What is certain is that the change has been swift, broad and largely unplanned. No committee voted, in 2008, to halve the length of the love song. Rather, a new economic infrastructure — built around streaming, the thirty-second threshold and the swiping thumb — has quietly reshaped, over fifteen years, what a popular song now sounds like. Whether the next generation will mourn the four-minute ballad, or find it as quaint as their grandparents found the seven-minute album track, remains to be heard. What we can say, for now, is that the form is changing under our ears, and that the change is not, in any meaningful sense, finished.

From Paragraph 1

12. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show that the shortening of pop songs is a **significant** and **widespread** trend. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. Explain, in your own words, why a record label finds it more profitable to release short songs than long ones. [2]

14. The writer describes the arithmetic as “brutally simple.” What does the word **brutally** suggest about the writer’s view of the industry? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. According to Paragraph 3, how has the **opening** of a popular song changed? Give **two** details. [2]

16. The writer says that slow builds and patient introductions “do not, in the cold language of the platform, **convert**.” Explain what is **effective** about the phrase “the cold language of the platform.” [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer notes that the phrase “attention economy” has been “used so often that it has worn smooth.” What does this phrase suggest about the writer’s attitude to the term? [2]

18. Why does the writer include the figure from the 2023 University College London study? [1]

From Paragraph 5

19. Producer Finneas O’Connell argues that the shortening “has as much to do with **craft** as with commerce.” Explain, in your own words, what he means. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. Give **two** arguments from Paragraph 6 that **defenders** of the trend might use to support shorter songs. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says that “no committee voted, in 2008, to halve the length of the love song.” Explain what is **effective** about this sentence. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why pop songs have become shorter**, and **what is gained or lost by the change**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Pop songs have grown shorter because ...

— END OF PAPER —